

end-to-end optic solution. Generally though, DSL is what would be used, seeing as we are talking about phone operators. The bandwidth afforded by a DSL loop is considerably less than ideal. However, since not all channels are simultaneously multicast, the problem is greatly alleviated.

An Interactive View

One of the benefits of IPTV is video-on-demand, or VOD. It means exactly what it implies—instead of waiting on your favourite show, you can watch it when you want to. This generally works with the help of a VOD server, which stores content made available for such a demand, and handles requests to that end. A multicast stream, however, does not allow for VOD. This is because VOD is essentially a unique service—like Batman's hotline to Commissioner Gordon! To enable this feature, the local operator creates a unicast stream to your house. This stream connects your TV to the VOD server mentioned, opening access to all your *Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu* needs.

You also get VCR-like control over a video stream. This allows you to pause, rewind or forward a show as you see fit. IPTV can also bring digital video recording (DVR) to your TV, if such functionality is offered by the set-top box. A DVR-enabled box can be used to record important cricket matches, for example. Over IPTV, a DVR can not only record a show while you are watching another, it can also record multiple shows simultaneously (bandwidth willing). Since all this is digital, you can also see multiple picture-in-picture applications.

As we touched upon earlier, the telco at the heart of all this handles more than just video. Imagine the service leveraging its access to the Internet to bring you your e-mail, or its access to the phone lines to bring you your phone calls. Imagine then, a scenario in which you are notified by a small pop-up of an incoming e-mail while watching a show. Or imagine taking a video call as a picture-in-picture overlaid on a football match that just *cannot* be missed.

There will also be the relatively mundane enhancements to your TV experience: interactive TV guides on your favourite shows, perhaps linked to user reviews and ratings. Pay-per-view could also be offered via such guides.

Another great functionality could be a process wherein you only pay for what you watch, although this is unlikely to happen—channels generally wrap their hit shows with assorted crud, and will therefore continue to offer, and charge for, so-called bouquets... of crud.

Vive La Révolution?

IPTV is not the only means of viewing video content over the Net. Services such as YouTube (www.youtube.com) allow users to share video content over the WWW. Even Google is on it, with its Google Video service, which is unfortunately not yet available in India. We can imagine an amalgamation of content sources and a variety of streams that will entertain us in the years to come. Take Google for example: in the US, it plans to cover cities with Wi-Fi access; free, ad-sponsored Wi-Fi at that. Down the line, Wi-Fi can be replaced with WiMAX with its mile-wide blanket of coverage.

AOL recently unveiled In2TV—a streaming TV Web site accessible over the Internet. Apple with its iPod/iTunes combination, and Microsoft with its PlaysForSure/Windows Media devices, can both offer a wide range of audio and video content over personal computers, laptops, PDAs, portable media players, and so on.

Pretty soon, everywhere you turn, TV will be there, waiting. You will no longer need to stay home to be able to be able to plug in, turn on and cop out. Question is—is that a revolting or a revolutionary thought? ■

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A recent MAIT and Ernst & Young research report has revealed that the Indian electronics hardware sector is expected to touch \$42 billion by 2010. The requirement for hardware manpower is estimated to be 12 lakh by 2010. Network security, WAN and wireless network administration were popular courses in 2004-2005 and indicated potential for further growth too. India urgently faces a shortage of around 200,000 IT and ITES professionals. The shortage is bound to grow to 3.6 million in the next eight years. According to

a Nasscom-Mckinsey study, India needed at least 830,000 IT professionals in 2004, but manpower still lags behind by 175,000. In 2006, there is another 400,000 fresh demand to be met. It will increase to another 300,000 in 2009 and by 2012 it will reach 1.6 million. Considering the above survey and observing the global market, there has never been a better time to invest in Networking and Internet Security Training. Both sectors, individually and jointly are poised for remarkable growth.

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